

HALFLINGS WITHOUT A HEARTH



WE PRESENT TWO NEW HALFLING TYPES. NOMAD Halflings and Swamp Halflings.

Halflings Without a Hearth is a monster supplement for 5e that presents halflings not as pastoral villagers or comic relief, but as marginalized cultures shaped by exclusion and survival. Instead of relying on a single generic halfling stat block, this book provides two distinct and escalating NPC ladders: wandering nomad caravans and insular swampbound criminal families.

These are not alternate ancestries. They are alternate outcomes.

The intent of this product is social tension and environmental identity. Nomad halflings represent displacement, pacifism under pressure, and the constant search for belonging. Swamp halflings represent territorial adaptation, criminal opportunism, and uneasy pacts with murky powers. Each ladder escalates not simply in strength, but in responsibility, influence, and cultural weight.

Jurisdictions, geography, and history are intentionally undefined. These NPCs can represent roadside caravans driven from kingdom to kingdom, marsh-dwelling smugglers controlling contraband routes, or distant cousins whose shared ancestry fractured long ago. They are not meant to replace traditional halflings—they exist at the margins of society, where hearthfires burn low or not at all.

How sympathetic they are, how dangerous they become, and whether they can ever reclaim a home is left entirely in the GM's hands.

NOMAD HALFLINGS

"WE STAYED UNTIL THE STONES WERE THROWN."

Nomad halflings are a people in motion. They travel in small caravans of wagons, tents, and pack animals, carrying what little they can salvage before being pushed onward again. They are not conquerors. They do not seize land. They do not fortify. When conflict arises, they move.

They are pacifists by culture, not by weakness. Violence threatens the caravan, and survival depends on cohesion. Every role within the ladder supports movement: scouts to find safe camps, guards to delay pursuit, elders to remember safer roads, and leaders who decide when another attempted settlement has failed.

Nomads are designed for consequence-driven and morally complex encounters:

- The party is hired to remove them from land they do not own.
- A caravan seeks protection through hostile territory.
- A town's paranoia escalates into violence.

- A wandering group carries stories of something terrible following them.

Nomad halflings are not meant to be dungeon inhabitants or territorial bosses. If they are fighting to the death, their culture has already collapsed. Their strength lies in endurance, organization under pressure, and the ability to disappear before the final blow falls.

They are always looking for a hearth. They rarely find one.

SWAMP HALFLINGS

"THE MUD KEEPS WHAT THE CITIES THROW AWAY."

Swamp halflings (sometimes referred to as swabbits) chose a different answer.

Where nomads wander, swamp halflings root themselves in places others refuse to claim: marshes, bogs, mangrove channels, and stagnant backwaters. They build reed huts and mud burrows in terrain that repels settlement, and they thrive there. What others call filth, they call shelter.

They are loosely bound by family ties rather than communal identity. Loyalty is personal. Territory is practical. Their settlements are not villages—they are networks: hidden docks, contraband caches, trap-lined approaches, and secret trails through knee-deep water.

Criminal enterprise sustains them. Smuggling, black-market trade, illicit harvesting, and quiet disappearances all fall within their domain. Their slight supernatural edge comes from familiarity with the swamp's older powers—minor spirit pacts, hexes whispered over stagnant pools, fog that lingers too long.

Swamp halflings are designed for:

- Underworld intrigue in difficult terrain
- Ambush-heavy wilderness encounters
- Illicit trade networks that stretch into cities
- Territorial conflicts where the environment is the true weapon

They are not conquerors either. They do not seek cities. They control margins—places too wet, too foul, or too inconvenient for anyone else to claim.

NOMAD HALFLINGS

Name	Challenge Rating	Description
Nomad Halfling Child	0	Noncombatant youth raised on the road. Accustomed to constant travel, sudden departures, and forming bonds that may be broken by expulsion.
Nomad Halfling Wayfarer	0	Caravan laborer, cook, tent-mender, driver, and gatherer. Avoids confrontation and focuses on keeping the people fed, sheltered, and ready to move.
Nomad Halfling Watcher	1/8	Night sentry and early-warning lookout. Armed with sling or shortbow but trained to signal danger and withdraw rather than stand and fight.
Nomad Halfling Scout	1/4	Pathfinder who rides ahead to locate safe camps, water sources, and viable roads. Skilled in concealment and retreat rather than direct engagement.
Nomad Halfling Caravan Guard	1/2	Defensive protector who interposes between aggressors and the caravan. Fights only to delay pursuit and secure organized withdrawal.
Nomad Halfling Elder Guide	1	Keeper of oral history and remembered migration routes. Advises when to settle briefly and when it is time to move on.
Nomad Halfling Trailwarden	2	Veteran protector responsible for evacuation strategy, rear-guard tactics, and ensuring no one is left behind during flight.
Nomad Halfling Hearthspeaker	3	Cultural and spiritual leader who preserves songs, traditions, and shared identity during long migrations.
Nomad Halfling Caravan Steward	4	Recognized leader of the wandering band. Makes final decisions regarding movement, negotiation, and when to abandon another failed settlement.
Nomad Halfling Waykeeper	5	Legendary figure who carries generational memory and embodies the endurance of a people forever searching for home.

SWAMP HALFLINGS

Name	Challenge Rating	Description
Swamp Halfling Whelp	0	Filthy, sharp-eyed youth raised in reed huts and mud burrows. Already accustomed to swamp rot and secrecy.
Swamp Halfling Forager	0	Scavenger and trap-layer who gathers carrion, shellfish, fungus, and vermin while navigating hidden marsh paths.
Swamp Halfling Mirewatcher	1/8	Concealed lookout who monitors swamp approaches and signals family when strangers enter their territory.
Swamp Halfling Snarehand	1/4	Trap specialist and petty thief who entangles, disables, or lures targets into prepared ambush points.
Swamp Halfling Bogknife	1/2	Close-quarters enforcer armed with coated blades. Fights brutally before vanishing into fog and muck.
Swamp Halfling Rotbroker	1	Black-market dealer who traffics in contraband, stolen goods, and illicit swamp resources across nearby settlements.
Swamp Halfling Mire Stalker	2	Veteran ambusher who moves silently through deep marsh and strikes from concealment.
Swamp Halfling Fen Hexer	3	Practitioner of murky bog magic who binds minor swamp spirits, spreads subtle curses, and manipulates fog and vermin.
Swamp Halfling Mud Reaver	4	Ruthless family head who controls smuggling lanes, hidden docks, and criminal operations within the marsh.
Swamp Halfling Bog Sovereign	5	Reclusive and feared ruler of a marsh territory, sustained by secret pacts and command of hidden networks.

NOMAD HALFLING WATCHER

Small humanoid (halfling)

Armor Class 13 (leather armor)

Hit Points 13 (3d6 + 3)

Speed 25 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	15 (+2)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	13 (+1)	11 (+0)

Skills Perception +3, Stealth +4, Survival +3

Senses passive Perception 13

Languages Common, Halfling

Challenge 1/8 (25 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +2

Caravan Alert. If this halfling rolls initiative and is not surprised, allied nomad halflings within 60 feet have advantage on their initiative rolls.

ACTIONS:

Sling. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, range 30/120 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d4 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

Dagger. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 4 (1d4 + 2) piercing damage.

BONUS ACTIONS

Brave Withdrawal. This halfling can take the Disengage action as a bonus action.

REACTIONS

- Always attempts to signal allies before attacking.
- Avoids prolonged combat; disengages once reinforcements mobilize.
- Best used to trigger organized caravan response.
- Rarely surprised in wilderness settings.



NOMAD HALFLING HEARTHSPAKER

Small humanoid (halfling)

Armor Class 15 (studded leather)

Hit Points 105 (14d6 + 56)

Speed 25 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	16 (+3)	18 (+4)	14 (+2)	18 (+4)	16 (+3)

Saving Throws Wis +6, Cha +5

Skills Insight +6, Persuasion +5, History +4, Survival +6

Senses passive Perception 14

Languages Common, Halfling, two regional languages

Challenge 3 (700 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +2

Shared Resolve. Allied nomad halflings within 30 feet have advantage on saving throws against being frightened.

Spellcasting. This halfling is a 7th-level spellcaster. Wisdom is the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 14, +6 to hit with spell attacks). This halfling has the following spells available:

- Cantrips (at will): [guidance](#), [resistance](#)
- 1st level (4 Slots): [sanctuary](#)
- 2nd level (3 slots): [calm emotions](#), [lesser restoration](#), [pass without trace](#)
- 3rd level (3 slots): [beacon of hope](#)

ACTIONS:

Quarterstaff. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) bludgeoning damage.

BONUS ACTIONS

Song of Endurance (Recharge 5–6). As a bonus action, this halfling grants up to three allied nomad halflings within 30 feet temporary hit points equal to 10.

- Strengthens group morale during tense negotiations.
- Keeps the caravan cohesive under intimidation.
- Rarely attacks first — favors spells that prevent violence.
- Killing or harming this halfling severely destabilizes caravan morale.



SWAMP HALFLING SNAREHAND

Small humanoid (halfling)

Armor Class 14 (leather armor)

Hit Points 32 (5d6 + 15)

Speed 25 ft., swim 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
9 (-1)	17 (+3)	16 (+3)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)

Skills Stealth +5, Survival +4, Sleight of Hand +5

Senses passive Perception 12

Languages Common, Halfling

Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +2

Bog Walker. Difficult terrain caused by mud, shallow water, or thick vegetation does not cost this halfling extra movement.

Prepared Ground. This halfling has advantage on attack rolls against creatures restrained by a trap, net, or entangling effect.

ACTIONS:

Net Trap. *Ranged Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, range 15/30 ft., one target. *Hit:* The target is restrained (escape strength DC 13).

Bogknife. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

- Prepares battlefield before encounter begins.
- Targets strongest-looking opponent with restraint effects.
- Avoids toe-to-toe fighting.
- Will retreat through pre-set escape routes.



SWAMP HALFLING BOGKNIFE

Small humanoid (halfling)

Armor Class 15 (leather)

Hit Points 58 (9d6 + 27)

Speed 25 ft., swim 25 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	18 (+4)	16 (+3)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)

Saving Throws Dex +6

Skills Stealth +6, Survival +4, Intimidation +2

Senses passive Perception 12

Languages Common, Halfling

Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Proficiency Bonus +2

Ambusher. During the first round of combat, this halfling has advantage on attack rolls against creatures that have not yet acted.

Dirty Strike (1/Turn). Once per turn, when this halfling hits a creature with a melee weapon attack, it deals an extra 7 (2d6) damage if it has advantage on the attack roll.

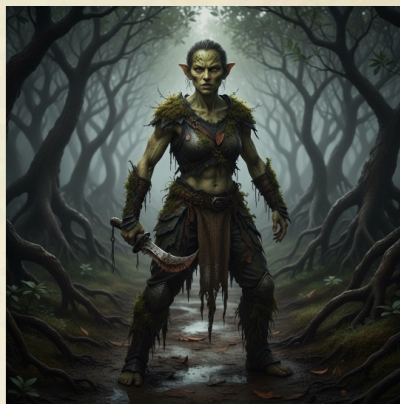
Swamp Skulker. This halfling has advantage on Stealth checks made in swamp terrain.

ACTIONS:

Multiattack. This halfling makes two melee attacks.

Coated Blade. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d6 + 4) piercing damage plus 3 (1d6) poison damage.

- Strikes first and targets isolated enemies.
- Uses fear and brutality to discourage pursuit.
- Retreats if surprise advantage is lost.
- Rarely fights honorably.



COMPATIBLE CONTENT

These halflings can be found in the wild [Wilderness Encounter Maps](#).

Swamp Halflings are commonly found in [swamp taverns](#).

Nomad Halflings are often encountered in [caravan taverns](#).

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